

Zak Elyazgi

PRODUCT • UX • RESEARCH • BRAND • CREATIVE
Design Leader

PORTFOLIO

zakelyazgi.com 

CONTACT

zak@zakelyazgi.com
703.229.8300
linkedin.com/in/zakelyazgi

Based in Fairfax, VA
Washington, DC Metro

LEADERSHIP FOCUS

Product Design Strategy
UX Strategy
People Leadership
Organizational Leadership
Cross-Functional Leadership
Creative Leadership
Brand Strategy
Design Operations
AI & Emerging Tech

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Enterprise Technology
Media & Entertainment
Federal / Government
Growth-Stage Companies
Startups / Ventures

EDUCATION

George Mason University
Bachelor of Arts,
Government & Politics

Strayer University
Undergraduate Certificate,
Information Systems
Programming Concentration

QUALIFICATIONS

With 25+ years leading UX, product design, creative, brand, and research, I build multidisciplinary teams and systems that turn complex challenges into clear, scalable experiences and measurable business outcomes. Known for raising standards, strengthening execution, and bringing product, UX, brand, and creative closer together, **I help organizations make design a trusted and valuable business capability.**

SELECTED LEADERSHIP IMPACT

Digital Transformation

Helped shift SiriusXM's digital transaction mix from 18% to 50% across experiences serving 12M+ monthly users, contributing to substantial annual call-deflection savings and stronger digital conversion.

AI Product Innovation

Led the LLM-powered evolution of Verisign NameStudio, introducing conversational domain discovery that increased engagement by 30%+ versus the non-LLM experience.

Organization Building

Established first-time UX practices and built and scaled multidisciplinary UX, research, creative, and digital organizations across multiple companies, including a 25-person globally distributed team led through three managers.

Zero-to-One Product Creation

Co-founded and took Grab from concept through live pilot, designing the product, service, and operating system behind a new hyperlocal delivery model spanning customer and courier experiences, fulfillment technology, inventory, brand, and operations — with average door-to-door delivery of 11 minutes.

DESIGN LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Senior Director, UX & Creative Services // *Verisign*
Oct. 2021 – Oct. 2025 (Promoted to Senior Director, Dec. 2023)

Led UX, research, creative services, project management, accessibility, vendor partnerships, and design operations across enterprise web, products, internal tools, global brand, and marketing within a \$20B+ publicly traded technology company generating \$1.5B+ in annual revenue.

- Built the operating model behind the function — including intake, prioritization, two-week sprints, capacity planning, workflow governance, and quality standards — improving delivery predictability, efficiency, and the team's ability to take on more complex work in-house.
- Led the end-to-end redesign of Verisign.com (120+ pages), achieving accessibility compliance, elevating brand perception, and delivering significant cost savings by executing internally rather than through agency outsourcing.
- Led the redesign of flagship product NameStudio, integrating LLM-powered AI to enable conversational domain name discovery, increasing user engagement by over 30%.
- Unified global brand guidelines and design systems, streamlining marketing workflows, reducing rework, and accelerating campaign launches worldwide.

Head of UX & Creative (Contract) // *Swth Communications*
Dec. 2020 – Aug. 2021

- Rapidly scaled and led a 25-person globally distributed team with three managers across three integrated verticals — UX & Creative, Motion Graphics & Animation, and Front-End Development — spanning the U.S., Turkey, Egypt, and Europe during a pivotal early-growth phase of the company.
- Designed and implemented the agency's core operating model, formalizing roles, workflow governance, delivery standards, and performance expectations to institutionalize accountability across disciplines.
- Elevated creative standards and execution rigor across verticals, strengthening delivery performance, meeting increasingly complex client demands, and establishing the operational backbone required for sustained growth.

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SELECTED CAPABILITIES

Agile Product Development
Design Systems
User Research
Experimentation & A/B Testing
Analytics & Optimization
Agency & Vendor Management
Creative Direction — Brand, Video,
Motion & Photography
Accessibility — WCAG & Section
508 Compliance

TOOLS & PLATFORMS

Figma
Adobe Creative Cloud
Analytics & Experimentation
Research & Testing Platforms

EARLIER EXPERIENCE

Senior UX Designer
SiriusXM

Senior Consultant, UX
Acumen Solutions

UX Designer
National Student Clearinghouse

UX Designer
Personal Pathways

Creative Director
UX & Graphic Designer
Daze Studios

Director, User Experience // Halfaker & Associates (Acquired by SAIC)
Sep. 2018 – Oct. 2021

Built and led the company's first UX practice, establishing human-centered design, research, and experience strategy as formal capabilities across complex federal and enterprise programs.

- Hired, mentored, and led a distributed team of designers and researchers while embedding UX into multidisciplinary product and engineering teams supporting high-visibility government programs.
- Established reusable research, design system, accessibility, and Agile-aligned UX practices that improved consistency, reduced delivery friction, and strengthened the quality of shipped experiences.
- Partnered with federal stakeholders, product owners, engineers, and program leadership across multiple workstreams to translate user insight and voice-of-customer data into clearer product direction and measurable improvements in usability and satisfaction.
- Elevated Halfaker's external UX presence through thought leadership and industry engagement, supporting new business opportunities and strategic partnerships during the period leading to the company's acquisition by SAIC.

Director, User Experience // SiriusXM
Jan. 2014 – Sep. 2018

Built and led SiriusXM's first in-house UX organization within a 34M-subscriber media enterprise generating \$5.8B in annual revenue, establishing the practice behind digital experiences serving 12M+ monthly users across ecommerce, account management, subscriptions, trial conversion, and content discovery.

- Helped drive a broader transformation toward digital self-service, with digital transaction mix increasing from 18% to 50% as millions of high-value customer actions shifted online, contributing to substantial annual call-deflection savings and stronger trial-conversion performance.
- Built the research, voice-of-customer, usability testing, and measurement capabilities that gave product and marketing teams stronger evidence for prioritization and continuous experience optimization.
- Co-founded and institutionalized SiriusXM's A/B testing program, connecting customer behavior and experimentation to product decisions across subscription, ecommerce, acquisition, and account-management experiences.
- Developed a unified UX pattern library and experience standards that reduced rework, strengthened consistency, and allowed proven interaction approaches to scale across SiriusXM digital properties.
- Led initiative to eliminate design-to-production friction by building front-end development capability within the UX team and assuming implementation ownership, materially improving shipped quality while reducing engineering workload.

VENTURE EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder & Head of Product Design & Marketing // Grab
Feb. 2022 – Feb. 2023

Co-founded and took a zero-to-one hyperlocal delivery concept from idea through live market pilot, shaping the product strategy, customer experience, service model, operating system, brand, and go-to-market approach around a 15-minute delivery promise.

- Designed the end-to-end product ecosystem across native customer and courier applications and an internal fulfillment platform, connecting ordering, inventory, order preparation, routing, delivery, and customer communication into one working system.
- Defined the operating model behind the experience, including curated inventory, dark-store fulfillment, scooter-based delivery, hot-food partnerships, and location handling for dense urban and university environments.
- Used real-world customer behavior, delivery operations, and firsthand service experience to continuously refine both the digital product and the operating model, ensuring the customer promise could be supported operationally — not simply marketed.
- Validated the model through a live Georgetown pilot with real customers and daily operations, achieving average door-to-door delivery of approximately 11 minutes, with some orders completed in as little as six.